

LX-003

What to Expect in Your First Legal Internship

Audience: Students | Stage: Once You're In | Read Time: 5 min

The Locus Playbook — by LexRoot
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01

Day one — what actually happens

Your first day will feel overwhelming, and that's completely normal. Most firms don't have a formal onboarding process for interns — you'll likely be shown to a desk, given Wi-Fi access, and told to "settle in."

Introduce yourself to everyone on your team — associates, other interns, even the office staff. Learn names. Ask your supervising associate what time they typically arrive and leave, what communication tools the firm uses (email, WhatsApp groups, internal systems), and whether there are any ongoing matters you should read up on.

Don't expect to do meaningful legal work on day one. Use the time to understand the firm's culture, read recent work product if available, and set up your workspace. First impressions matter — dress professionally, be punctual, and show genuine enthusiasm without being overbearing.

02

Types of work you'll be given

Internship work at Indian law firms generally falls into four categories: research memos (finding and summarising relevant case law or statutory provisions on a specific question), drafting (contracts, letters, notices, or sections of larger documents), due diligence (reviewing documents in M&A or real estate transactions), and administrative tasks (organising files, preparing bundles for court).

Don't turn your nose up at any of these. Even document review teaches you how deals are structured. Filing teaches you how litigation matters progress. Every task is a learning opportunity if you approach it with curiosity.

The quality of work you receive often depends on the quality of work you deliver. Nail the small tasks and you'll earn the trust to handle bigger ones. Fumble the basics and you'll be stuck with photocopying for the rest of your internship.

03

How to ask questions properly

Knowing when and how to ask questions is one of the most important skills you'll develop. The rule is simple: try to find the answer yourself first, then ask with context.

Bad question: "What is Section 138 of the NI Act?" (Google it.) Good question: "I've read Section 138 and the Supreme Court's decision in Dashrath Rupsingh Rathod. The firm's client

seems to fall under the amended jurisdiction rules, but I'm unsure whether the 2015 amendment applies retrospectively. Could you point me in the right direction?"

The second question shows you've done the work. It tells your supervisor exactly where you're stuck and saves them time. Always write down the answer — asking the same question twice is a red flag.

Timing matters too. Don't interrupt someone mid-draft or right before a court hearing. Batch your questions and ask during a natural break, or send a short email if the matter isn't urgent.

04

Tracking your work

Maintain a daily log of every task you work on. This isn't optional — it's the single most useful habit you can build during your internship. Record the date, the task description, the supervising associate, the deadline, and what you learned.

This log serves three purposes: it helps you write a meaningful internship report (many colleges require one), it gives you concrete talking points for future interviews, and it helps you track your own progress.

Use the Monthly Internship Log template attached to this guide. At the end of each week, review your entries and note any patterns — are you getting better at research? Are your drafts requiring fewer revisions? This self-awareness accelerates your growth.

05

End-of-internship checklist

Your last week is as important as your first. Here's what to do before you leave:

Complete all pending work and hand over any ongoing tasks with clear notes. Don't leave loose ends — this is the fastest way to damage your reputation.

Ask for a certificate of completion and, if appropriate, a letter of recommendation. The best time to ask for a recommendation letter is while your work is fresh in their minds, not three months later.

Thank everyone — your supervising partner, the associates you worked with, and the support staff. A short, genuine thank-you email to your supervisor goes a long way.

Connect with your colleagues on LinkedIn with a personalised note. These relationships are your professional network — nurture them. Finally, update your CV immediately while the details are fresh.

— End of Guide —